



RIGHT TO READ.
FREE LIBRARIES FOR ALL

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FROM READER TO USER

A discourse history of eighty years of Indian Library Association proceedings: how the library's reader became a user, and how the discourse kept caste unsayable.

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From Reader to User

Eighty Years of the Indian Library Association and the Changing Public of the Library, 1942–2019

RIGHT TO READ CAMPAIGN

Abstract

This paper reads eighty years of Indian Library Association conference proceedings (1942–2019), alongside the Delhi Public Library's founding records, the government library-committee reports compiled by the Central Secretariat Library, and the post-1990 parliamentary record, as depositions of a single discursive formation. It argues that the profession's drift from reader to user is the dissolution of a democratic reading subject into a system-function, and that this dissolution is the mechanism by which the discourse keeps the caste question unsayable. The state costed universal public-library provision repeatedly across a forty-five-year committee chain and refused it by deferral; the recurring claim that the library is a State subject is shown to be a declined reform rather than a constitutional given. Because the public library matters most to those who cannot buy books, disproportionately the caste-Bahujan poor, the refusal of universal provision is caste exclusion administered in neutral language.

KEYWORDS public libraries · India · caste · Indian Library Association · reading publics · discourse analysis · Delhi Public Library · UNESCO · digital libraries

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1 Introduction

Begin with the smallest unit of the thing: a person, and a book she has not paid for. For three-quarters of a century the Indian library profession argued, in conference after conference between 1942 and 2019, about who that person was and what the country owed her. They called her, by turns, the reader, the citizen, the adult learner, the rural masses, the user, the information seeker, the knowledge worker. Each name was a theory of the public; each renaming was a quiet decision about what a library is for. This article reads eighty years of that renaming — the forty published proceedings of the Indian Library Association, some nine million words — as the documented record of how a democratic state learned to imagine its readers, and then learned to stop.

Its argument is that the public library in India was promised as a commons and delivered as a deferral. From the last colonial decade the profession asked for one plain thing: a library free at the door, paid for from the public purse, guaranteed by a law that bound the State rather than merely permitted it. It asked across the founding of the Republic, across the Five Year Plans, across a National Policy on Library and Information Systems that was drafted in 1986 and never laid before Parliament. It was answered, each time, with a further committee, a model bill left “under active consideration,” a statute that might be brought into force “gradually within a period of twenty years.” When at last an answer arrived with the weight of a decision — in 1993 — it was to permit libraries to charge the reader a fee: the very subscription a committee had called, in 1939, of a public library, “a contradiction in terms.” The commons was not lost in a single act of destruction. It was avowed and deferred in the same breath, year upon year, until deferral set into a refusal that no minister ever had to sign.

To watch this happen, one has to read the profession’s own speech. Conference proceedings are not neutral technical literature; they are a record of what librarians, educators, and the administrators beside them found urgent, sayable, or unspeakable at each moment — and the words drift. Across the series the vocabulary of the reader, the public library, of adult and social education, of finance and legislation thins and gives way to the vocabulary of the user, of information, networks, quality,

management, the digital. The drift is not merely lexical. Read against two other archives — the government’s own compendium of committee reports, and the floor of Parliament, where the question was put and deflected for thirty years — it resolves into a single movement told three times: the reader becoming a user, the entitlement becoming a service, the commons becoming a connection one pays to keep.

There is, finally, a figure the record keeps just outside its frame. The library was offered as the caste-free room, the place where anyone at all might read; but the public it imagined — from its Brahmanical and princely genealogy to the committee-room “citizen” whose caste went unnamed — did not see who it left standing at the threshold. The free, open-to-all commons is precisely what a caste order has always resisted. The near-silence the proceedings keep on caste, never more than a fraction of a fraction of their nine million words, is not a gap in the record. It is the record’s deepest finding.

2 The Library Deferred: A National Obligation Never Enacted

The public library reached the Republic already freighted with a politics of access, and it arrived by two roads. One was princely and improving: by the 1920s a state like Baroda had built a state-supported library system — a modernity of letters handed down from above, to a public the ruler defined. The other was professional and movement-born: by 1941, on the eve of the transfer of power, S. R. Ranganathan could survey a “library movement” already conscious of itself, with its theory, its cadre, and its demand. That demand hardened quickly into a claim on the state. By the mid-1940s the Indian Library Association was asking not for charity, and not merely for professional recognition, but for an enforceable public obligation — a library guaranteed by central law, paid for from the public purse, free at the door. The profession arrived at independence, that is, asking for the library as a right. What the next eight decades would hand it instead was the library as a recommendation; and the distance between those two words is the subject of this section.

The planning state’s library vision had a flagship, and it was built for display. The Delhi Public Library was established in 1951 as a joint Government of India–UNESCO pilot project — one of two in the world, the other in Colombia — and consecrated across 1956–57, when UNESCO published the proceedings of the “Public Libraries for Asia” seminar it had hosted there (1956) and its evaluation report of the library (Public Library Manuals, Vol. 8, 1957). Its stated purpose was to “adapt modern techniques to Indian conditions” and to serve as “a model public library for Asia” (Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture, Rajya Sabha 2022). By 1955 UNESCO could call it “the busiest and most modern public library in Asia” and use it as “the headquarters and the ‘laboratory’ ” for a seminar drawing delegates from twelve Asian countries (Unesco 1956).

The institution belongs to the founding wave of the republic: the Constitution in force in 1950, the Planning Commission in 1950, the First Plan and the Delhi Public Library in 1951. It was the work of the Ministry of Education under Maulana Abul Kalam Azad — the same ministry that would convene the Advisory Committee for Libraries in 1957 — with Nehru as its symbolic apex; his ninety-minute visit to the 1955 seminar, filmed for newsreels across India, was staged as the project’s benediction. The library expressed a Nehruvian self-image: non-aligned, developmental, and addressed to Asia. To read it as merely a building is to miss that the same postwar state had already made Delhi the convening-capital of anticolonial Asia at the 1947 Asian Relations Conference. The library-as-“model

for Asia” is one node in a wider knowledge-infrastructure imaginary — conferences, institutes, area-studies schemes, state publication — through which the new state staged Delhi as a capital of Asian knowledge (Elhalaby 2025). This is a relation of conditions of possibility, not cause: the conference did not produce the library; the same state produced both.

The library’s universalism is worth reading closely, because it is euphemistic. In his inaugural address Azad located India’s backwardness in the history of restricted reading — great libraries had existed, he said, but had served only a few:

[T]he benefits of these libraries were confined to royalty and the nobility ... knowledge was not widespread among the masses. One main reason why India fell behind Europe is to be found in this restriction of libraries for the use of only a selected few. (Unesco 1956)

“Today,” he concluded, “democratic India ... is providing facilities for education and enlightenment for all her children.” The diagnosis is half-right and tellingly coded: the monopoly on letters is named as feudal — “royalty and nobility,” “a selected few” — never as caste. The remedy is an undifferentiated “all her children,” a reading citizen whose caste the state does not name.

That silence has a face. The most consequential reader of the era, B. R. Ambedkar — who held that every person should spend a tenth of their income on books, and who assembled a personal library of some fifty thousand volumes at Rajgriha because the public and Brahmanical order of letters had been built to exclude him — resigned from Nehru’s cabinet in 1951, the very year the Delhi Public Library opened its universal doors. The corpus records no comment from him on the library itself. He is the absent reader at its founding: the figure who made the caste monopoly on the written word the centre of his politics, leaving the government as it inaugurated a “library for all” that would not say the word. The Delhi Public Library’s universalism and Ambedkar’s exit are the two halves of the planning state’s relation to the reader — the promise, and the unnamed exclusion it is built upon.

That exclusion was older than the Republic, and it was already doubled. The Bombay legislature that in 1939–40 declined a library cess and chose only permissive provision was the same Assembly in which Ambedkar then sat; and the legislator who had moved the 1936 Bombay Public Libraries Bill, S. K. Bole, was the very man whose earlier resolution to throw open public places to untouchables had set off Ambedkar’s Mahad water satyagraha of 1927. Ambedkar pressed Bole on public access (Ambedkar 2020); on the record he did not speak on the library bill. The man who in 1916 had argued, as a student at Columbia, that a public library would be a finer memorial than a statue, and who kept a free reading room for the Depressed Classes at Clarke Road, was — in his own movement’s account of Mahad — a figure “unable even to take water from a public watercourse or to read in a public library in Hindustan, the land of his birth” (Ambedkar 2019). Water and the library, the two public goods this article reads together, were for him a single caste boundary; and at the founding of each provision they were settled without him.

Whether the public library becomes a state obligation or stays a professional aspiration has a documentary answer, and it is the latter. The demand was stated early and exactly. At its sixth conference in 1944 the Indian Library Association resolved that “the Library Act must be one promulgated by the Central Legislature,” and faulted its own 1942 draft Bill for making the Act “permissive and adoptive, instead of a mandatory and compulsory piece of legislation”; given rural poverty a local rate “cannot be thought of,” so “the Government of the country must finance the scheme.” Central, mandatory, tax-funded, free: the terms of the obligation were set at the origin, and never met.

The refusal was in fact older than the organised demand, and it turned on a calculation about money. The founding calculation debate sits in the Library Development Committee, Bombay (1939-40), whose chapter on legislation weighs the one mechanism that could make libraries free at the point of use — a library cess on the English and American model, of the kind the Bombay Presidency Public Libraries Bill (No. XXIV of 1936) had already proposed before it was “introduced in the Legislative Council, but ... not further considered.” The committee declines it:

[P]eople are not prepared for any additional tax ... and ... even if a special cess was levied people were not sure that it would be necessarily utilised for that purpose. ... Compulsory legislation is not necessary at present ... permissive legislation may be enacted to authorise any Municipality or Local Board to levy a special tax, if they so desire.

Permissive rather than compulsory, optional rather than owed: the structure of the deferral is fixed in 1939, before the central-Act demand is fully voiced — and the committee’s own doubt, that a cess might not “be necessarily utilised for that purpose,” is precisely the failure the system would confirm eighty years later.

The committee chain restated them for half a century without enacting them. The first post-independence national report, the Advisory Committee for Libraries under K.P. Sinha (reported 1958), held that a national Library Law should incorporate “the right of every citizen to have free access to libraries as his fundamental right,” funded not by fees but by a cess — “a library rate of 6 naye paise in a rupee of property-tax” — while deferring the law’s operation “gradually within a period of twenty years.” The Working Group on the Development of Libraries during the Fourth Five Year Plan (1966-71) was firmer still: the Central and State Governments “should share among them the entire responsibility of providing adequate public library services to the citizens,” a Directorate of Libraries in every State, a minimum of Rs 30.99 crore over the Plan, and a Draft Bill it “prepared for consideration.” The Centre’s own Model Public Libraries Bill (1963), circulated to the States, then settled into a permanent holding pattern: in the 1964 proceedings it is “under the active consideration of the State Government” with a decision “likely to be taken very soon” — a sentence the record keeps repeating and the statute book never honours.

The form of the refusal is recurrence without enactment. Each committee re-recommends what the last committee’s recommendation failed to make real, and deferral is written into the instruments themselves: “permissive” legislation (1944), a twenty-five-year finance horizon and a twenty-year operation clause (1957), a “Draft Bill for consideration” (1966). The cost of the gap between avowal and provision is legible in the per-capita figures the profession recorded against itself: public-library spending of about 2.9 paise per head in 1963-64, and roughly three paise — Rs 0.03 — per head by the early 1980s, with only a small minority of villages served. The obligation was always affirmed and never appropriated.

The arithmetic deserves to be set in one place, because it is the consistency that makes the argument. Decade after decade the State costed universal provision, in detail, and then declined to pay for it.

Table 1: What the committees calculated, and what the State provided. Source: the Central Secretariat Library's compendium of government library reports (Central Secretariat Library 2003).

Committee (year)	What it costed or required	Enacted or funded?
Library Development Committee, Bombay (1939–40)	a library cess, weighed and declined; only <i>permissive</i> legislation proposed	no obligation created
Advisory Committee for Libraries, chaired by K. P. Sinha (appointed 1955, reported 1958)	free access as a fundamental right; a cess of 6 naye paise per rupee of property-tax; a twenty-five-year plan to make the whole system free by the Sixth Plan	not enacted
Working Group, Fourth Five Year Plan (1966–71)	Rs 30.99 crore for public libraries, Rs 20 crore for book production, a Directorate of Libraries in every State, and a Draft Bill	Bill never enacted; sums never appropriated
NAPLIS, Empowered Committee, follow-up Working Group (1986–93)	provision pared to a charge on the reader	declared a “State subject”; libraries permitted a Re. 1 to Rs. 10 membership fee

Against every line in that table, the expenditure actually delivered stayed near zero. They calculated for forty-five years; they funded almost none of it.

After 1986 the deferral acquired a name to defer. The Committee on the National Policy on Library and Information System (CONPOLIS), under D.P. Chattopadhyaya, submitted its report in 1986; an Empowered Committee filed comments in 1988; a Working Group in 1992 found the recommendations “difficult to implement” and pared them down, and the residue was “accepted” in 1993. There the obligation was not merely deferred but inverted. The central recommendation — shared Centre-State responsibility for a public-library system — was answered with “‘Library’ being a State subject, the Department of Culture ... is not in a position to take direct action,” and downgraded to a provision that libraries “may [charge] Re. 1/- to Rs. 10.00 ... as nominal membership fee” — the very subscription the 1944 committee had called, of a public library, “a contradiction in terms.” The profession registered the result without illusion: the 1994 proceedings record that the Department of Culture “has not yet placed [NAPLIS] before the Parliament ... As a result, the NAPLIS is yet to see the light of the day,” and the 1999 proceedings that “No further action has been taken, on the report by the government.”

What the committee chain deferred, the constitutional division of powers then naturalised. On the floor of the Rajya Sabha the national public-library question is met, with increasing regularity from the late 2000s, by three interchangeable formulas — that libraries are “a State subject” (from 2022, “as per the Seventh Schedule”), that there is “no such proposal” or “no data maintained,” and that the petitioner should look to the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation. In 2006 the government conceded that the 1985 committee notwithstanding, “a National Policy of Public Library and Information has not been declared.” In 2018 a question asking why civic bodies collect the library cess “as part of the

property tax” and fail to deposit it with the library institutions was answered only that “Library is a state subject” — the cess levied on the public and not passed on, with the Union disclaiming the remedy. By 2025 the answer had reduced to its elements:

The subject ‘Libraries’ comes under State list. No such data is maintained. ... There is no such plan.

The State List does the work that “permissive legislation” and the twenty-year clause once did: it converts a sustained political refusal into a jurisdictional fact, an obligation that is formally nobody’s.

The same hollowing is legible in the statutes the States did pass. Where the central Act never came, a model did: the draft Library Bill S. R. Ranganathan completed in 1948, enacted that year as the Madras Public Libraries Act (Madras 1948) and recirculated through the Centre’s Model Public Libraries Bill (1963) and the Indian Library Association’s later Model Act, supplied a template that nineteen States eventually adopted. Read as a set, against that model, the Acts record not nineteen designs but one form copied with a diminishing substance (Figure 1; Table 2). The model’s defining instrument was a dedicated library cess — a surcharge on property or house tax, earmarked — the one device that could make a library free at the door without an annual plea to the treasury. Of the nineteen Acts only six carry an operative cess: Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and its Telangana successor, Karnataka, Kerala, and — levied on liquor excise rather than property — Goa (Madras 1948; Andhra Pradesh 1960; Telangana 1960; Karnataka 1965; Kerala 1989; Goa 1993). One, Haryana, keeps the word and never fixes a rate (Haryana 1989); Uttarakhand preserves the cess machinery while renaming the levy a “fee,” its drafters leaving behind a clause that forbids delegating “the power to levy library cess” the Act no longer grants (Uttarakhand 2005). Every other Act passed after 2000 drops the cess outright (Gujarat 2001; Orissa 2001; Uttar Pradesh 2006; Rajasthan 2006; Bihar 2008; Chhattisgarh 2008; Arunachal Pradesh 2009), as the no-cess Acts of Maharashtra, West Bengal, Manipur, and Mizoram had before them (Maharashtra 1967; West Bengal 1979; Manipur 1988; Mizoram 1993). The matching grant that once tied state money to the cess collected survives in fewer still. The further each Act sits from 1948, the less of the model it keeps: the administrative shell — a State council, a Director, a Library Fund — is reproduced faithfully; the fiscal obligation inside it is quietly deleted. The permissive-not-compulsory choice the Bombay committee made in 1939 was, in the end, federalised — the form of the library spread across the statute book while the commitment that would have funded it did not.

And across all nineteen, the reader the founders would not name stays unnamed. Not one Act guarantees access irrespective of caste; “free,” where it appears at all, is a by-law forbidding an admission fee or an adjective in a preamble, never the equality the 1957 committee had called a fundamental right. The single exception proves the rule by its origin: only Kerala’s Act, written on the back of the Granthasala Sangham’s mass library movement, builds mandatory representation for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and women into the bodies that govern its libraries (Kerala 1989). Everywhere else the statute addresses an undifferentiated public whose caste it does not see — Azad’s “all her children,” now multiplied across a federation of Acts.

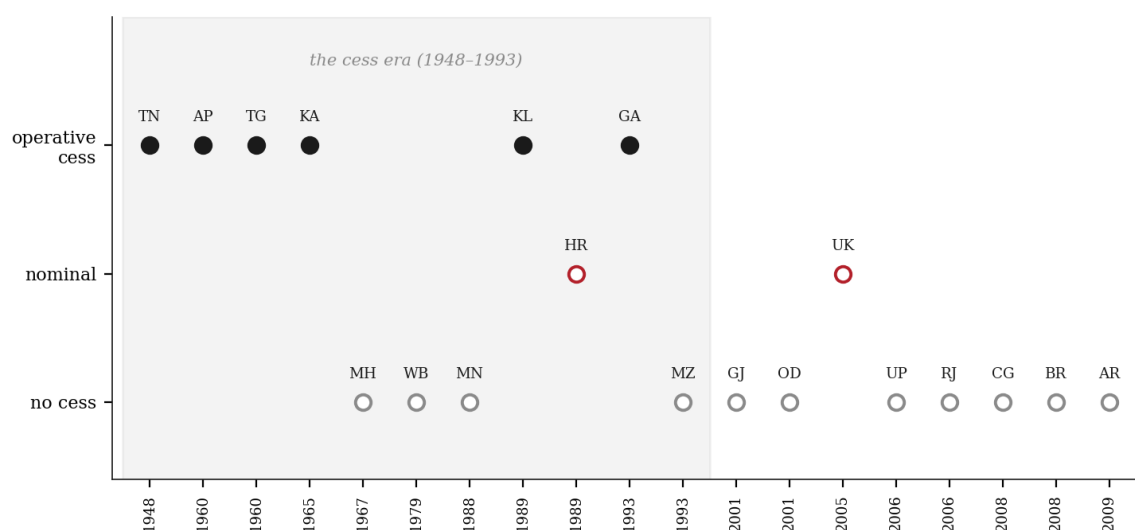


Figure 1: **The cess, abandoned.** Each enacted State Public Libraries Act by year of enactment and funding instrument: an operative library cess (filled), a nominal one — a provision carrying no rate, or a cess renamed a “fee” (open red) — or none (open grey). Every working cess falls inside the 1948–1993 “cess era”; every Act enacted since 2000 omits it. State codes are spelled out in Table 2. Source: the bare-act texts (see Data and Code Availability).

Table 2: The nineteen State Public Libraries Acts read from primary text — funding instrument, obligation, access language, and template lineage. Only six carry an operative cess; only one names caste. Source: the bare-act texts (see Data and Code Availability).

State (year of Act)	Library cess	Duty to provide	Names caste / equality	Template lineage
Madras / Tamil Nadu (1948)	operative (3 paise)	enabling	—	model parent
Andhra Pradesh (1960)	operative (4–8 paise)	duty	—	Madras line
Telangana (1960)	operative (8 paise)	duty	—	Madras line (= AP)
Karnataka (1965)	operative (3 / 6 paise)	duty	—	Madras line
Maharashtra (1967)	none	enabling	—	Bombay-successor
West Bengal (1979)	none	enabling	—	Madras line, no cess
Manipur (1988)	none	duty	—	Madras line, no cess
Kerala (1989)	operative (5 paise)	duty	SC/ST + women	<i>sui generis</i> (movement)
Haryana (1989)	provision, no rate	enabling	—	Madras line
Goa (1993)	operative (liquor)	service mandatory	—	Bombay / <i>sui generis</i>
Mizoram (1993)	none	programmatic	—	RRRLF “system”

State (year of Act)	Library cess	Duty to provide	Names caste / equality	Template lineage
Gujarat (2001)	none	enabling	—	Bombay-successor
Odisha (2001)	none	enabling	—	Madras line, no cess
Uttarakhand (2005)	cess → “fee”	duty	—	Madras line (hollowed)
Uttar Pradesh (2006)	none	enabling	—	RRRLF model-bill
Rajasthan (2006)	none	enabling	—	RRRLF / modern
Chhattisgarh (2008)	none	enabling	—	UP clone
Bihar (2008)	none	aspirational	—	outlier
Arunachal Pradesh (2009)	none	“shall establish”	—	RRRLF “system”

The profession ratified the retreat even as it protested it. By 1997 the proceedings can state that “the days of free-service have gone by; the fee-based services are a viable alternative,” and the 1999 Library Vision 2010 that “Information will be available at a cost” — the free-access right of 1944 and 1957 abandoned in the professional register itself. And the record names the only avenue it has left: in 2011, sixty-four years after independence, a paper asks “should we wait till some one files a PIL in the Supreme Court to make the public welfare achieved?” The public library never crystallised into a state obligation. It dissolved from a mandatory central Act demanded as a fundamental right (1944-57), into a model bill perpetually under consideration (1963-), into a diluted policy reduced to a membership fee (1993), into a question of “informatics” and “technology” (1985-95), and finally into a matter on which the Union maintains no data and has no plan (2025) (Figure 2).

3 The Commons Refused: Library, Food, Water

The public library’s deferral is one instance of a wider grammar, and two neighbouring goods show its range. Food is the case where the commons was forced into a right against the State’s reluctance: the People’s Union for Civil Liberties’ 2001 writ persuaded the Supreme Court to read a right to food into the Article 21 right to life — “no person goes hungry when the granaries are full” — and the right was finally legislated as the National Food Security Act, 2013 (Tillin 2024). That this route exists, and that the library never travelled it, is exactly what the 2011 library proceedings register when they ask whether the profession must “wait till some one files a PIL in the Supreme Court.” Yet even the won right is hollowed in the giving — prioritised in some states and abandoned in others (Chhotray et al. 2020), and resting on the unpaid domestic labour that turns subsidised grain into a meal.

Water runs the other way, from right toward commodity, and India built the conversion deliberately. Its instrument is not the meter but a doctrine — the “sense of ownership.” Rural water supply was reformed from 1999, through the Sector Reform pilots and then Swajaldhara (2002), onto a World-Bank-informed “demand-responsive approach” in which a village must first mobilise a share of the capital cost —

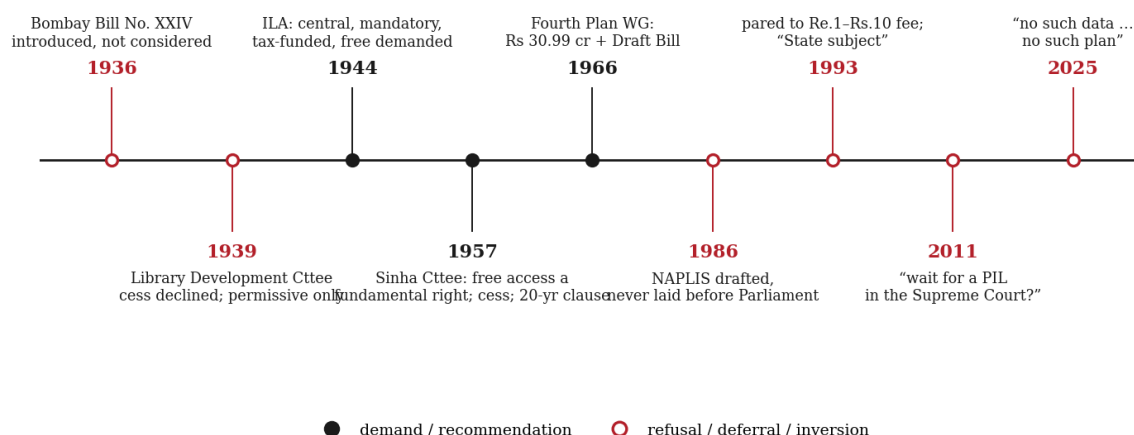


Figure 2: **Costed, then declined.** Eighty years of the public-library obligation: each demand or committee recommendation (filled) met, on both sides, by refusal, deferral, or inversion (open). Events are spaced evenly so the sequence is legible; the bold dates give the actual chronology. Sources: ILA proceedings; the *CSL Compendium* (Central Secretariat Library 2003); the Rajya Sabha record.

typically ten per cent — before it is served, on the premise that what is not paid for is neither valued nor maintained (Sampat 2007). The Jal Jeevan Mission (2019) carries the same architecture to scale: its operational guidelines require a community contribution of ten per cent of in-village capital cost (five per cent in hill and majority-SC/ST villages) and hand operation, maintenance, and the collection of user charges to a Gram Panchayat sub-committee — the Village Water and Sanitation Committee, or Pani Samiti — expressly, in the guidelines’ own words, “to instil the sense of ownership among the community” (Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Ministry of Jal Shakti 2019). Lest this read as incidental, the state has built a behavioural science around it: the first of the four intervention categories in the 2023 *Compendium of Behavioural Best Practices* for the Mission — authored by the Behavioural Insights Unit of NITI Aayog with the Centre for Social and Behaviour Change — is, in its own words, “Uptake and Payment for JJM services,” gathering “all interventions encouraging people to take up and regularly pay user charges ... for JJM services” (Behavioural Insights Unit, NITI Aayog et al. 2023). The work of making the rural poor pay for water is not a by-product of the scheme; it is a named object of governmental behaviour design. The unit of the good shifts from the well, the tank and the public standpost, which are collective and unpriced, to the household connection a family has helped pay to install and must pay to keep running. Critics caught the move in a pun: Swajaldhara, “our water,” becomes Pay-jaldhara (Sampat 2007). Tracked on a real-time governance dashboard rather than guaranteed as an entitlement, and arriving — where it arrives — as taps without water, the right to water is delivered in the shape of a serviced, chargeable account the user has been taught to think she owns because she pays for it.

What holds the three together is a common sense about the poor that had to be manufactured. The claim that people do not value what they do not pay for is not the poor’s own; it is a governing-class judgement, on record in the library papers from 1939, where the masses “have not yet realised the importance ... of education” and must have it “forced on them compulsorily.” After 1991 a cost-recovery doctrine gave the judgement a technical alibi — the user fee would teach “ownership” and

“accountability” — and the doctrine was then laundered as the people’s own demand, as when the 1994 library proceedings cite a survey that “more than 85% of the users viewed that the libraries should charge fees” and the 1993 decision sets the fee “keeping in view the economic condition of the target group of users.” Frontline ethnography of India’s reforming water utilities records the same rationality hardening into hostility toward a “public” of “demanding, unruly ... slum-dwellers” (Coelho 2004). And beneath the economics sits the older refusal: the free, open-to-all commons is precisely what a caste order has long resisted, and a fee re-segregates by purse what birth once segregated directly. The water the Jal Jeevan Mission now meters reaches, disproportionately, Dalit households; it is the same public water Ambedkar marched for at the Chavdar Tank in Mahad in 1927, when the right at stake was simply to drink from a public tank caste had closed (Ambedkar 2019). Then the barrier was the caste order; now it is the user charge — the commons the satyagraha fought to prise open, handed back as a bill. The library, the meal and the tap are governed by one move — the entitlement recoded as a service the user must deserve, maintain, and buy — and “the poor do not value free things” is the sentence that makes the State’s withdrawal read as the public’s choice.

4 The Information Turn and the Lost Commons

The information turn is usually read as a technological event: the arrival of the computer, the database, the network. Read against the term-drift evidence, it is also a conjunctural one. Across the full 1942-2019 series (all forty proceedings, 9.3 million words), the profession’s vocabulary breaks hardest in the blocks bracketing 1991 — user rising from 13.0 (1970-85) to 34.8 (1986-99) to 47.1 (2000-08) per 10,000 words, information from 69 to 114 to 136, while public_library falls from its planning-era peak of 26.8 (1950-69) to 8.1 (1986-99) and then 4.1 (2000-08). That break straddles three events that arrive together: the fall of the Berlin Wall in 1989 and the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991; the Indian balance-of-payments crisis and the liberalisation of 1991; and the first public reach of the internet across the decade that followed. For the library these are not three events but one. The profession’s own language registers the moment the library stopped being imagined as a commons and began to be imagined as a terminal (Figure 3).

What was the commons that was lost? It had two registers, neither of them the state’s flagship institution — the Delhi Public Library, founded in 1951 as the first UNESCO Public Library Pilot Project, was a modernisation instrument, a “model public library for Asia.” The first register was the planning state’s own vision of public-library provision as a public obligation. The Advisory Committee for Libraries (reported 1958), chaired by K.P. Sinha, the first post-independence report to treat public-library development extensively, framed the library through social and adult education and laid out a finance plan running from the Third to the Seventh Plan. The Working Group on Development of Libraries during the Fourth Five Year Plan (1966-71) went further: it held that the Central and State Governments “should share among them the entire responsibility of providing adequate public library services to the citizens,” recommended a Directorate of Libraries in every State, a minimum of Rs 30.99 crore for public libraries and Rs 20 crore for book production over the Plan period, and prepared a draft Model Library Bill to bind the obligation in law. This was the library as a public claim on knowledge, stated by the developmental state in its own words.

The second register was collective rather than statal. It lived in the reading rooms. In Kerala the *granthasala* and *vayanasala* were the organising cells of the communist movement — “where there is

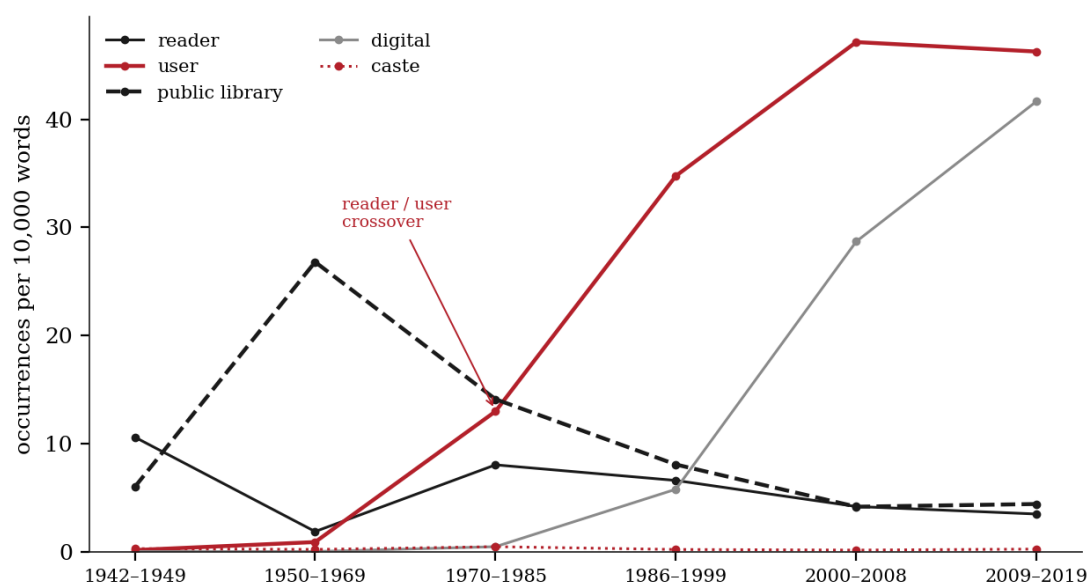


Figure 3: **The reader becomes a user.** Normalised frequencies (occurrences per 10,000 words) across the forty ILA proceedings, 1942–2019. *User* overtakes *reader* in the 1970s and *public library* after its 1950s–60s peak; *digital* surges after 2000; *caste* never leaves the floor (never above 0.45). *Information* is held off-scale (it peaks at 136 per 10,000 words). Source: the term-drift counts in `term_drift_by_period_1942_2019.csv`.

a local party office there is a library” — and the library was less a repository than an “energizing script of self-improvement,” a site where a collective political subject was made (Thiranagama 2026). That subject had a material base. The cheap Soviet book — Progress and Mir imprints, moved through the state export monopoly Mezhdunarodnaya Kniga and distributed in India through a network of Communist Party book houses (People’s Publishing House, Visalaandhra, Navakarnataka, Prabhath), from a central node at the USSR Book Centre on Connaught Circus in Delhi — made a left reading economy viable at prices Indian commercial editions could not match (Soviet Review 1981; Rajagopalan 2023; Chakrabarti 2019). Reading room and subsidised book were two halves of one infrastructure of collective reading. India’s was one side of a Cold War contest over the reading public: the United States ran its own state-subsidised book diplomacy in parallel, the Franklin Book Programs (Khalifa and Haddadian-Moghaddam 2025).

After 1991 both registers lost their backbone at once. The rouble-rupee book trade collapsed with the state that subsidised it, and liberalisation re-commercialised the Indian book market in the same years; the state’s own provisioning ambition, never fully realised, was quietly abandoned rather than renewed. With the socialist alternative gone, “access to knowledge” was free to be recoded — from a collective good secured by public provision into a service delivered to an individual through a network. This is the deeper content of the reader-to-user shift: the *user* is the reader stripped of the collective. One reads in a commons; one queries a system alone.

That the rupture was selective is the point. The Indo-Soviet relationship did not end in 1991; it was re-based — from books to weapons-and-barrels. The strategic and military axis survived the collapse and was formally renewed: the 2000 Declaration on Strategic Partnership restored the inter-state framework, Soviet- and Russian-origin platforms remained the installed backbone of the Indian armed forces, and after 2022 discounted Russian crude climbed from under two per cent to roughly a third of India’s oil imports. What was not renewed was the knowledge register: the subsidised book, the

translated text, the reading economy. Russia rebuilt the arms supply and opened the oil supply; it never rebuilt the book (Dyakonov 2023). Of everything the partnership carried, the collective reading commons was the first thing both states treated as dispensable. The reading commons died; the arms and oil pipelines did not. The library's loss of its commons was, in this light, not an accident of the Soviet collapse but a choice about what in that collapse was worth saving.

The internet's rise did not merely add a tool to this settlement; it occupied the conceptual space the public-library commons had vacated. The promise that information could be made costlessly available over a wire arrived precisely as the institution embodying the public claim on knowledge was being defunded and re-described. The recoding is legible in the state's own reports, not only the profession's: where the 1966 Working Group spoke of a responsibility to the citizen, the Eighth Plan Working Group on Libraries and *Informatics* (1990-95) and the Planning Commission's Core Task Group on the Sharing of Library and Information *Technology* renamed the same object as a problem of systems and connectivity. Hence the misidentification that still organises Indian knowledge policy: that digital connectivity *is* library provision. The proceedings of the 2000s and 2010s, where digital climbs from near-absence to 28.7 (2000-08) and then 41.7 (2009-19) — the one term still rising at the end of the series — while *public_library* (4.1) and *finance* (0.6) reach their lowest recorded levels, are the professional voice of that substitution.

The loss is doubled by caste, and here the section must refuse nostalgia. The commons that 1991 dissolved was never the open commons it claimed to be. The reading room was proposed as a caste-free associational space but reconstituted caste rather than abolishing it, building a “national popular” reading public that consistently occluded Dalit participation (Thiranagama 2026); the planning state's provisioning vision, for its part, addressed an abstract “citizen” whose caste it did not name. The displacement of the library by the network is therefore not the fall of an achieved equality. It is the substitution of one caste-occluding form of access — the collective that assumed caste away — for another — the individualised terminal that assumes connectivity away. The constitutional reader for whom reading is an unfinished anti-caste claim is absent from both. In the term-drift series caste never exceeds 0.45 per 10,000 words — across all forty volumes and 9.3 million words — and stands at 0.23 in the most recent (2009-2019) block. That near-silence, running across the whole 1942-2019 record and straight through the rupture of 1991, is itself the finding this paper is built to read.

If 1991 hollowed the commons, the two decades that followed renamed what was left. The proceedings of the 2000s read like a glossary of a new dispensation — Quest for Quality, the Electronic Information Environment, Responding to Users' Need, Information Literacy and Lifelong Learning, the Information Commons. The reader, once a citizen and an adult learner, becomes a “user” to be satisfied; the library becomes a service to be managed; provision becomes “quality.” The state's own elite supplied the charter: the National Knowledge Commission's working group on libraries (2006) restated the knowledge-economy case and was answered as every committee before it had been — forwarded, noted, not made binding. “Lifelong learning” and “information literacy” carried the husk of the old social-education mission forward while emptying it of its collective and fiscal content; an obligation to a citizen became a service to a user and a skill for an individual.

By the 2010s the recoding had a slogan, Digital India, and the library returns in the record only as a node — next-generation, embedded, networked, digital. The single term still climbing at the end of the series is the digital itself, even as the words *public library* and *finance* sink to their lowest recorded levels. Here is the misidentification that now governs Indian knowledge policy, and it should be named

without euphemism: the belief that connectivity is provision — that a wire and a screen will let a poor but literate public leapfrog the slow, costly, staffed, vernacular labour of building places to read. A connection is offered where a commons was owed. The platform does not extend the public library; it settles into the space the public library was never permitted to occupy.

5 What the Archive Shows

The preceding chapters trace a vocabulary. This one reads what the vocabulary is the symptom of. Three independent record-sets — the ILA proceedings, the government library reports compiled in the Central Secretariat Library's 2003 *Compendium of Select Government Reports on Library and Information Services in India*, and the post-1990 parliamentary record — turn out to be depositions of a single discursive formation: one that constitutes the Indian reading public as a caste-blind universal whose coherence depends on caste remaining unsayable, and whose material correlate is a costed-then-refused provision. Four operations hold that formation together.

The state did not neglect the public library; it studied it, repeatedly, for forty-five years, and the studying was the form the neglect took. The *Compendium* (Central Secretariat Library 2003) assembles the chain: the Advisory Committee for Libraries (Sinha, 1957); the Fourth Plan Working Group (1966-71); the Seventh Plan Working Group on Modernisation (1985-90); the Committee on a National Policy on Library and Information System (NAPLIS, 1986) and its Empowered Committee (1988); the follow-up Working Group (1992); the Eighth Plan Working Group on Libraries and Informatics (1990-95); the Core Task Group chaired by A.P.J. Abdul Kalam (1995); and the Ninth Plan Working Group (1997-2002). Across this chain the same four structural reforms are recommended and re-recommended: a binding national policy or legislation; a National Commission on Library and Information System; and the explicit extension of service to the “weaker sections,” “backward areas,” and “neo-literates.” None of the three was enacted. No national library law; no National Commission; public libraries remained a State subject; provision decayed to the per-capita floor of a few paise a head. The repetition is not a failure within the discourse but the discourse's function: each committee re-discovers the identical problem, re-recommends the identical fix, the fix is not enacted, and a new committee is constituted to re-study it. The committee chain is the institutional form of the refusal — the state performing perpetual concern as the technique of withholding provision.

Two artefacts in the chain are decisive. First, the state's own admission of elite capture: the 1995 Core Task Group recorded that the country's information infrastructure had “rather low” impact because “the services are not effective due to limiting its users only to scientists in elite institutions” — and answered that diagnosis with more networks and digitisation, not universal provision. Second, the “State subject” deflection is exposed as a *declined reform*. The constitutional location was never the binding constraint: under the State List six States both legislated and levied a dedicated library cess, and the Centre has long funded libraries directly through the Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation and, since 2014, the National Mission on Libraries — so universal provision is fully available where the library already sits, and is simply withheld. (The one constitutional fix an official body did float — the National Knowledge Commission's proposal to “include libraries in the Concurrent List of the Constitution of India by an Act of Parliament” — was dropped by the Commission itself within weeks, gone from its 2007 roadmap (National Knowledge Commission 2006, 2007).) Every subsequent “libraries are a State subject” answer therefore cites as a constitutional given what is in fact a political

refusal the state chose to make.

Read archaeologically rather than lexically, the reader-to-user shift is not a change of words but a change in what the library constitutes as its subject. Across the proceedings the library is successively an instrument of civic formation (the reader as a citizen-in-the-making), then planned infrastructure (the citizen with a claim), then a node in an information system (the user as a function of that system), then a digital access-point (the user as beneficiary or data-subject). The movement is from a *person* — to be emancipated, who holds a claim — to a *function* — a query, a footfall, a download. This is why the term-drift matters beyond its arithmetic: the dissolution of the reading person into the system-function is precisely what renders the caste question unaskable. One can ask of a person, but not of a function, who by caste is permitted to read. The discourse protects itself not by denying caste but by dissolving the subject of whom the caste question could be asked.

The flat near-absence of caste across the series — never above 0.45 per 10,000 words, across forty volumes and 9.3 million words — is not a gap but a condition. The discourse can constitute its universal reader only on condition that caste remains unspeakable; to name caste would be to concede that the reading subject is caste-structured and the universal false. The silence is what makes the universal coherent. The decisive artefact is Gore's 1955 survey of the Delhi Public Library: a full apparatus of measurement — sex, age, occupation, education, distance — with no category for caste. The instrument was built unable to see caste. Azad's inaugural address performs the same operation in speech: it sees the historical monopoly on letters ("the restriction of libraries for the use of only a selected few") but can name it only as feudal, "royalty and nobility," before dissolving it into "all her children." The unsayable thing is the true thing.

The silence has a history. Across the twentieth century the Indian reading public was constituted three times over. The nationalist library movement — fused to the freedom struggle, its association meeting alongside sessions of the Indian National Congress — imagined a universal "common man" who was caste-blind. The communist library — the Kerala *granthasala*, the study circle — made reading an act of political consciousness but built what its own historians call a "national popular" that "consistently occluded Dalits' participation." And the anti-caste tradition — Phule's schools, Periyar's and Sahodaran Ayyappan's reading rooms, the Travancore movement, Ambedkar — constituted reading as specifically an anti-caste act: the Bahujan reader, caste-explicit. Of the three, only the anti-caste tradition ever named caste. The national library settlement universalised the nationalist reader, absorbed the communist energy into "social education," and never institutionalised the anti-caste reader at all. The caste-silence of the professional and state discourse is therefore not an oversight but the trace of a won contest: the caste-blind reading public defeated the caste-explicit one at the level of the state, and the silence is what that victory sounds like.

The "library as people's movement" was never a single national movement; it was a constellation of regional reading-movements, and it is in the regions that the contest between the three publics is documented. The Proceedings of the Indian History Congress preserve two of them: Priolkar's account of the Bombay Presidency movement (Priolkar and Priolkar 1947) and, more sharply, G. Samba Siva Reddy's study of the reading rooms of Rayalaseema, 1858–1947, whose very title — "Creating Consciousness Among the Colonised" — names reading as a political act (Reddy 2009). The Telugu country is the densest case. The Andhra library movement, organised from 1914 through the *Grandhalaya Sangham* under Ayyanki Venkata Ramanayya (1890–1979) (Venkatappaiah and Madhusudhan 2006), built the institutional substrate of the regional public sphere that Rama Sundari

Mantena reconstructs — a “public politics based on liberal ideas of public reason and debate” across the Telugu districts of Madras and princely Hyderabad (Mantena 2014). That same Andhra Mahasabha and its reading publics carried, at their radical edge, into the Telangana armed struggle of 1946–51 (Sundarayya 1972) — reading as revolutionary consciousness, the Andhra counterpart to the Kerala *granthasala* (Thiranagama 2022) and the Tamil Arivoli Iyakkam (Cody 2013). These vernacular libraries were, as Boyk, Amstutz and Perkins argue, “constructed and maintained beyond the ambit of the colonial or post-colonial states” yet “deeply enmeshed in varied state projects” (Boyk et al. 2020). The national settlement did not build on this regional energy; it absorbed it. After 1960 the regional reading-movement was professionalised into “social education” and “public library legislation,” and its political and anti-caste charge drained out. The question the regional record forces is the one the national discourse cannot ask: when Reddy’s reading rooms created consciousness “among the colonised,” and Mantena’s public sphere convened the Telugu “public,” whose consciousness, and which public — and was the Dalit reader inside it, or its constitutive outside?

The silence is specific, not generic. In the 1996 *Daedalus* issue “Books, Bricks, and Bytes” — a single volume in which the postwar library establishment reframed itself around the digital transition — the postcolonial chapters name their societies’ stratification: the South African chapter names race and apartheid (Lor 1996), the Brazilian chapter names social inequality in its very title (Sant’Anna 1996). The Indian chapter (Banerjee 1996), narrating “the story of libraries in India” in the same volume and under the same digital-future frame, does not name caste. The comparison is the control: the silence is not a universal feature of postcolonial library discourse, which elsewhere could say its inequality. It is specific to the Indian caste case. What the other national stories could say, the Indian one could not.

These are not three datasets and a comparison but four faces of one formation. The state calculates the cost of a universal reading public and refuses it by deferral; the profession dissolves the reading person into a system-function; both produce a universal reader whose coherence requires caste’s unsayability; and the comparative record shows that this unsayability is the Indian case’s signature, not the genre’s. A public library matters most to those who cannot buy books — disproportionately the caste-Bahujan poor — so the refusal of universal public provision is caste exclusion administered in the neutral languages of fiscal priority, “State subject,” and “digital access.” The reports calculate what including the Bahujan reader would cost; the formation’s work is to ensure the calculation never becomes a library, and the exclusion never becomes a sentence with the word “caste” in it. To read that silence as the answer is the task this paper sets itself.

Across eighty years the archive shows a profession forever translating the library into the dominant language of the day — reconstruction, planning, information policy, management, digitization — and paying for each translation in the only currency that mattered: the stability of the reader it was meant to serve. The democratic subject of the library never held still. She was named the reader, the adult learner, the citizen, the student, and then unnamed into the user, the information seeker, the knowledge worker — each renaming a step further from a person with a claim on the state, a step closer to a customer with a need to be met.

The right to read cannot be rebuilt in the language that dissolved it. No quantum of connectivity restores a commons that was never funded, and no platform answers a claim the State spent half a century learning not to hear. To recover the right to read is to recover the public library as what the demand of 1944 already knew it had to be: public, fiscal, linguistic, and anti-caste infrastructure — free at the door, paid from the common purse, held in the languages people actually read, and built

first for the readers the commons was designed not to see.

6 Methodology and Data

The study reads three archives together. The spine is the forty published proceedings of the Indian Library Association, 1942–2019, acquired from the Association’s collection on the National Digital Library of India; beside them sit the government’s committee reports, compiled in the Central Secretariat Library’s 2003 *Compendium*, and the post-1990 parliamentary record. The proceedings survive as scanned image PDFs, and were run through optical character recognition (OCRmyPDF and Tesseract) to yield a searchable text layer, with provenance and per-volume quality logged.

The method is mixed, and the order of authority is fixed. Normalised term counts across the series — the rise of *user*, *information*, *quality*, *management*, and *digital*, against the fall of *public library*, *finance*, and *adult education* — are used only for discovery: they show where to read, not what to conclude. Every claim that bears weight in the argument rests on a passage checked against the original page image, never on the OCR or the counts alone. The full corpus, the term-drift tables, the OCR-quality audit, and the verification record are deposited as set out under Data and Code Availability.

7 Limitations and Future Work

This is a working draft, and its evidentiary base is uneven in ways a next version must repair. The parliamentary record read here is partial: the Lok Sabha question files in the corpus survive only as title stubs, so the floor history quoted above is drawn from the Rajya Sabha, and only from 1995 onward; the deep debates of the 1950s and 1960s wait to be recovered from the printed Debates. The term-drift counts rest on optical character recognition of scanned proceedings, complete for the figures cited here but not yet for every volume. The figures on which the argument leans have been checked against the original page images: the 1957 cess of six naye paise, the Fourth-Plan estimates of Rs 30.99 and Rs 20 crore, the 1993 membership fee of one to ten rupees, and the per-capita expenditure of 2.9 paise (1963–64) and Rs 0.03 (early 1980s). The Advisory Committee chaired by K. P. Sinha was appointed in 1955 and reported in 1958, recommending free library service as a right; catalogue dates for the report vary between 1958 and 1959, and the *Compendium* reprints it under a 1969 running head. The counts of how many states had passed library legislation drift between sources and even within single volumes, and each must be pinned to the statute before it is repeated. Finally, the comparative material on food and water is offered as analytical triangulation, not primary research of equal depth, and each would repay an archival study of its own.

8 Data and Code Availability

The derived data and analysis code for this paper — the OCR and term-drift scripts, the term-drift and OCR-quality tables, and the page-image verification ledger — will be deposited in the Right to Read working-paper series’ Open Science Framework project, with the code archived for a citable version DOI on Zenodo (DOIs to be assigned). The three primary source bodies are cited to their own repositories rather than re-hosted here: the forty Indian Library Association conference proceedings (1942–2019), held on the National Digital Library of India; the CSL *Compendium of Government Reports on Library and Information Services in India* (2003); and the Rajya Sabha question-and-answer

record (1995–2025). All figures and quoted passages are verified against the original page images. The deposited derived data are released under CC-BY-4.0 and the analysis code under the GNU Affero General Public License v3 (AGPL-3.0).

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